house in order before we went over to the other side. Nobody bothered to listen.

But as we say in my language: it's not that the knife is sharp; it is your stomach that's weak.

Our thinking is limited. Pakistanis compete with each other more than they compete with outsiders. This may be our biggest failing as a nation. Our insecurities get the better of us. It's always about X Pakistani batsman saying I played better than Y Pakistani batsman. Pakistani bowler A wants to be faster than Pakistani bowler B. He doesn't want to scalp AB de Villiers or rip apart Virat Kohli – which, by the way, is his real job. There's a team within the team. And it's captained by self-interest and petty politics.

What went wrong in the 2016 World T20? We made a strong start but after losing to India, we just kept on losing. I tried to do what I could individually but towards the end, I must admit that I wasn't in control of my team. It was every man for himself, really. That's exactly what seemed to be happening on the field, and publicly too.

Frankly, we were out of form. New talent wasn't emerging (I had openly displayed my concern about that too, and have explained it earlier in detail). There was a chronic shortage of fresh blood. And the guys who were coming into the team, well, I didn't feel the fire in their bellies. They were giving up easily. They were soft. That's not cricket. It's definitely not Pakistan cricket.

In the buildup to my retirement in 2016, a lot changed. There was a lot on my mind when I decided to hang up my boots and walk away. Just before the World T20 in India, I wanted to quit for good. My performance wasn't up to par. I was failing consistently in terms of my own performances. So was the team. If the team would have reached the semis or even the final, then at least I would have looked good on my way out.

Sounds egomaniacal? Yes. I wanted to leave on a high note. Can you blame me? After 20 years of international cricket, wouldn't you want a glorious exit? But even quitting hasn't been easy for me. There was a lot that was off-kilter. We were not looking solid as a unit for years, particularly since the spot-fixing controversy. Even friends who had been there and done that came in with advice which unfortunately backfired.

For example, I asked Imran Khan to come and see the boys before the India game at the World T20. That meeting turned into something else, a total disaster, really. First, we waited for him for hours so he could come and say something inspiring. Unfortunately, when he did arrive, the pep talk turned into a therapy session for some of the team members. Umar Akmal even complained about his place in the batting order. How juvenile! So instead of preparing us mentally to play India, Imran went on to wax eloquent about the bloody methodology of the batting order. What a wasted opportunity!

What's more, when Imran returned to Pakistan, he fired a missile – he claimed the team was under pressure and we couldn't handle the situation in India[1.] It was a real disaster. As for Akmal, or all those who I have played with or against, any player who seeks soft corners or makes excuses isn't really a player. He's a supplicant. He's just doing a job, not playing the game. He can't take the pressure. Umar Akmal could not. Sorry buddy, but that's what I really feel.

So that is the context of what was going on in the team before it was curtains for me in 2016. Yet, I wasn't all there, be it on the field or off it. That's why I decided I would take a final call on arriving back in Pakistan. Sometimes, home offers you more than just comfort. It offers you a chance to introspect. I needed closure.